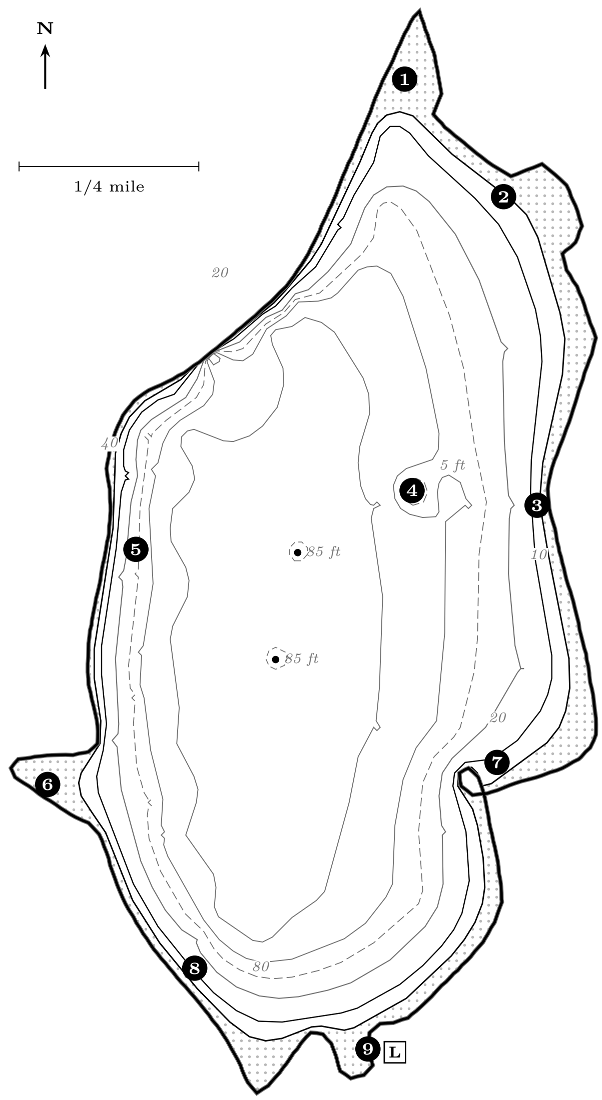
Pine Lake

Town of Merton & Village of Chenequa

Waukesha County, Wisconsin — 711 acres, 85 ft maximum depth

Pine Lake is deep, cold and startlingly clear, and almost everything that makes it hard to fish follows from those three facts. Ninety per cent of the bottom is gravel. The water clears far enough that weeds grow past 15 ft, that fish see your line, and that the best bites come at the edges of the day. It stratifies hard by early summer into a warm upper layer and a cold, oxygenated basin below, and it holds cisco — an open-water forage fish — which means the biggest predators in this lake spend much of the summer suspended over 60 ft of water rather than sitting on the weed edge where you would like them to be.

Surface	711 acres (698 acres on the 1955 survey); 6.7 miles of shoreline
Depth	85 ft maximum, 39 ft mean — one of the deepest lakes in the county
Bottom	Gravel 90%, muck 5%, sand 5%. Hard bottom nearly everywhere
Clarity	Very clear. Expect weed growth to 15–20 ft and spooky fish in calm sun
Fish	Largemouth and smallmouth bass (common), panfish, northern pike, walleye (stocked as large fingerlings in alternate years), cisco
Access	One public launch, Village of Chenequa. 6 a.m.–10 p.m., except the general fishing opener when it opens 4 a.m.–midnight. Launch fees apply (roughly \$8–\$15 by boat length); verify current hours and fees



Depth in feet. Schematic — not for navigation. Redrawn from the Wisconsin Conservation Department lake survey of 6 June 1955 (WBIC 779200), published by the Wisconsin DNR as a public document. Contours are reconstructed from that survey's soundings and are generalized.

under 5 ft — shoreline — 5 & 10 ft — 20 ft — 30 ft — 40 & 60 ft — 80 ft — 4 spot — L public launch

The nine spots, by season

Depths below are where the fish are, not where the spot is. Everything on this lake runs deeper than you expect because the water is so clear.

#	Spot	When & what	How
1	North arm shallows	**Apr–early Jun:** bluegill, pumpkinseed, largemouth, early pike. **Nov–Mar:** panfish under ice.	First water in the lake to warm. Fish 3–8 ft over emerging weed. Slip bobber and a small leech or half a crawler; a weightless wacky-rigged worm for bass.
2	North-east shoreline break	**May–Jun** smallmouth; **Sep–Nov** walleye and pike.	A scalloped shore with points and pockets and a fast drop. Work the points with a jig-and-minnow along the 12–20 ft line; cast tubes to the rock in spring.
3	East wall	**Jul–Sep** smallmouth, walleye, suspended fish.	The steepest drop in the lake — 20 ft is a short cast from shore. Drop-shot or a slow lindy rig down the 25–40 ft face. Best at first and last light.
4	**Mid-lake bar**	**Jun–Oct**, the whole cast: smallmouth, walleye, crappie, big pike.	A hard 5 ft crest surrounded by 60 ft. The single best piece of structure here. Start on top at dawn, then follow the fish down the sides to 18–30 ft as the sun climbs. Jig-and-minnow, drop-shot, or a deep crankbait on the edge.
5	West shelf	**May–Sep** largemouth and bluegill; **Oct** pike.	The gentlest slope in the lake, with the deepest weed growth. Fish the outside weed edge at 12–18 ft. Texas-rigged plastic through the weeds, slip bobber on the edge.
6	West bay	**Late May–Jun** bluegill and pumpkinseed on beds; largemouth all summer. **Jan–Feb** panfish.	Shallow, protected and weedy — the classic spawning bay. Small hook, small bait, light line, and stay back from the beds. Prime water to put a child on fish.
7	South-east bay	**Apr–May** crappie and bluegill; **Jun–Aug** largemouth.	A small round pocket that warms early and holds spring fish before the main lake turns on. Slip bobber over 6–12 ft.
8	South-west taper	**Sep–Nov** walleye and pike; **Jun–Aug** smallmouth deep.	Deep water swings close to the bank here. Troll or drift the 20–35 ft break with a lindy rig and a big minnow in fall.
9	Outlet bay	**Apr–May** and **Oct–Nov** pike; panfish in summer.	Shallow, weedy, with some current. Pike stage here early and again in fall. Big sucker on a quick-strike rig under a float, or a spinnerbait over the weed tops.

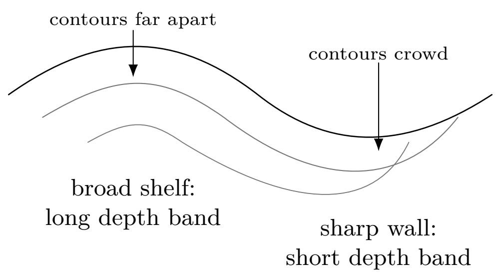
Build a three-stop route

Start at spot ______ to test ____________________; move to spot ______ only if ____________________; finish at spot ______ to compare ____________________. Keep ____________________ unchanged across all three stops.

Reading the year

Ice-out–April	Everything is shallow and everything is in the bays. Spots 1, 6, 7, 9. Water under 50 °F: slow down, use bait.
May–June	Spawn moves through in order — pike first, then walleye, then bass, then panfish last on the beds. Fish stay shallow. Bass season opens the first Saturday in May; check the current dates.
July–August	The lake stratifies. Panfish and largemouth hold the deep weed edge (spots 5, 6); smallmouth, walleye and big pike go to the bar and the east wall (3, 4) or suspend over the basin chasing cisco.
September–October	Turnover scatters fish for a week or two, then the best fishing of the year begins. Big fish move up onto structure and eat hard. Spots 2, 4, 8.
November–ice	Deep and slow. The bar and the east wall hold fish into December.
Ice season	Panfish in the bays (1, 6); pike on tip-ups over the weed edges. *Walleye, bass and pike close 7 March; panfish stay open.*

Learn to see the break



The map gives you shapes, not today's fish. Work these questions in pencil before the boat goes in:

1. At spots 2, 5 and 8, draw a cast that begins shallow and crosses the 20-ft contour. Which cast samples the widest band of bottom?
2. Put the boat on the deep side of spot 3. How far can wind move you before a vertical presentation is no longer on the wall?
3. Trace two routes from the top of spot 4 to 40 ft. Circle the one exposed to today's wind. That is a hypothesis about activity, not an answer.
4. Mark one shallow bay, one weed edge, one hard break and one open-water scan. What observation will make you abandon each?

Write the prediction first
I expect fish at ____________ ft near spot ____ because ______________________. I will give that idea _____ minutes or _____ clean passes. Evidence that defeats it: ______________________.

What only today's lake can tell you

Claim	Field test
The weed edge is 15–20 ft	Cross it on two headings and record where continuous living growth actually stops.
The gravel break holds fish	Require repeatable sonar marks, bait, contact or bites at a recorded depth; hard bottom alone is not a pattern.
Predators are chasing cisco offshore	Scan two basin routes and match marks on reciprocal passes. One arch is not a school.

Make three measurements the same way

1. **Fix the stations.** Pick a protected bay, the west shelf and a basin-side structure. Note the map number or lawful waypoint. Return to these same stations rather than choosing prettier water each trip.
2. **Depth.** Outside traffic, let sonar settle and record depth on opposite headings. A marked sounding line is a useful check only with propulsion stopped, PFD worn, and line kept away from feet and propeller.
3. **Temperature.** Shade the thermometer. Wait for a stable surface reading, then repeat at 5, 10 and 20 ft where possible. Use equal wait times. Write “not measured” when wind or depth prevents a safe reading.
4. **Clarity.** On the shaded side, lower a black-and-white Secchi disk until it disappears. Raise it to reappearance. Average the depths; repeat once. Stay seated or braced and stop if waves make leaning unsafe.
5. **Describe the test.** Record wind, sky, recent rain, traffic, surface debris, vegetation height and whether the reading was stable.

Do not manufacture a thermocline

Four temperatures can show a useful change, but not a complete profile. They do not prove dissolved oxygen. Use a calibrated oxygen meter if oxygen matters; otherwise leave it unknown.

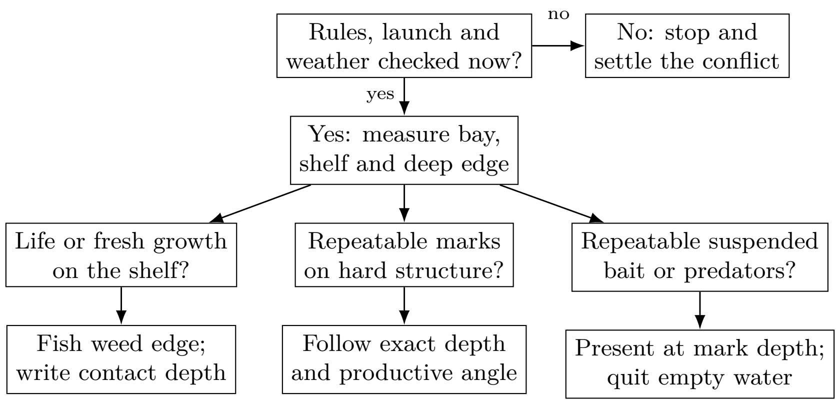
Pine water log

Date/time	Station	Depth ft	Temp: surface/5/10/20 ft	Secchi: down/up/mean ft	Wind, growth, bait, confidence

Questions after the third station

1. Where did the two depth headings disagree most? ________. Was the cause likely slope, weeds, waves, speed or instrument setup?
2. The clearest station was ________; its Secchi mean was ____ ft. Did fish or bait sit shallower or deeper there?
3. Which observation contradicted the written seasonal pattern? ________________. What is the cheapest next test?

Let evidence choose the next move



Departure gate

Verify today	Evidence, source, time	Go?
Exact-water regulation and season		Yes / No
Launch sign, hours, fee and ordinance		Yes / No
Forecast, radar, wind direction and gusts		Yes / No
Lightning, fog, waves or high-water notice		Yes / No
PFDs, lights, communication and return route		Yes / No

THE LAKE GETS THE LAST WORD

Recheck at the launch. If the posted rule differs from a saved note, follow the current authoritative direction. If observed wind, lightning, visibility or waves exceed the crew or craft, do not launch or come back immediately.

Evidence notebook

Time / spot	Claim tested	Evidence for and against	Next move and reason

CHECK THE REGULATIONS BEFORE EVERY TRIP

The 2026–27 rules for this water are: largemouth and smallmouth bass 14 in minimum, 5 per day, 2 May–7 March, catch-and-release the rest of the year; walleye 18 in minimum, 3 per day; northern pike 26 in minimum, 2 per day; muskellunge 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only through 31 December; panfish 25 per day; cisco and whitefish 10 per day. **These change.** The Wisconsin DNR publishes the current rules for this exact water body, and only that publication is authoritative.

Close the loop at home

One trip, one revised belief

The strongest repeated evidence was ______________________________. It supports / weakens my prediction because ______________________________. On the next trip I will hold ______________ constant and change only ______________.

1. Transfer useful waypoints with date, water level context and confidence; delete accidental marks and never rename a guess as a hazard.
2. Compare all three stations before calling a lake-wide pattern.
3. Note the first observation that changed your plan and whether changing early saved time.
4. Clean, drain and remove plants and animals before moving equipment.
5. Recheck this workbook's seasonal claims after three comparable trips.

Next-trip control sheet

Hold constant	Tool / station / depth / presentation / time window
Measurement method	
Comparison station	
Change one thing	New test and the result that would reject it
Fishing variable	
Map claim	